

HOW TO GET A WEAPON

- The applicant has to approach a police commissioner's office or the district magistrate, fill a standard form stating he/she needs a weapon for self-protection or sport. He has to prove the need for self-protection by producing a written police complaint or prove a history of threats.
- However, the unwritten rule is that only those with the right connections can actually get a licence—a Member of Parliament, for instance, can recommend a gun licence.
- The police, however, must be convinced that the applicant has a genuine need for the weapon and that he/she has no criminal record.
- Once the licence is issued, the applicant can buy the weapon directly from ordnance factories, another licence holder, authorised gun dealers or import the weapon.

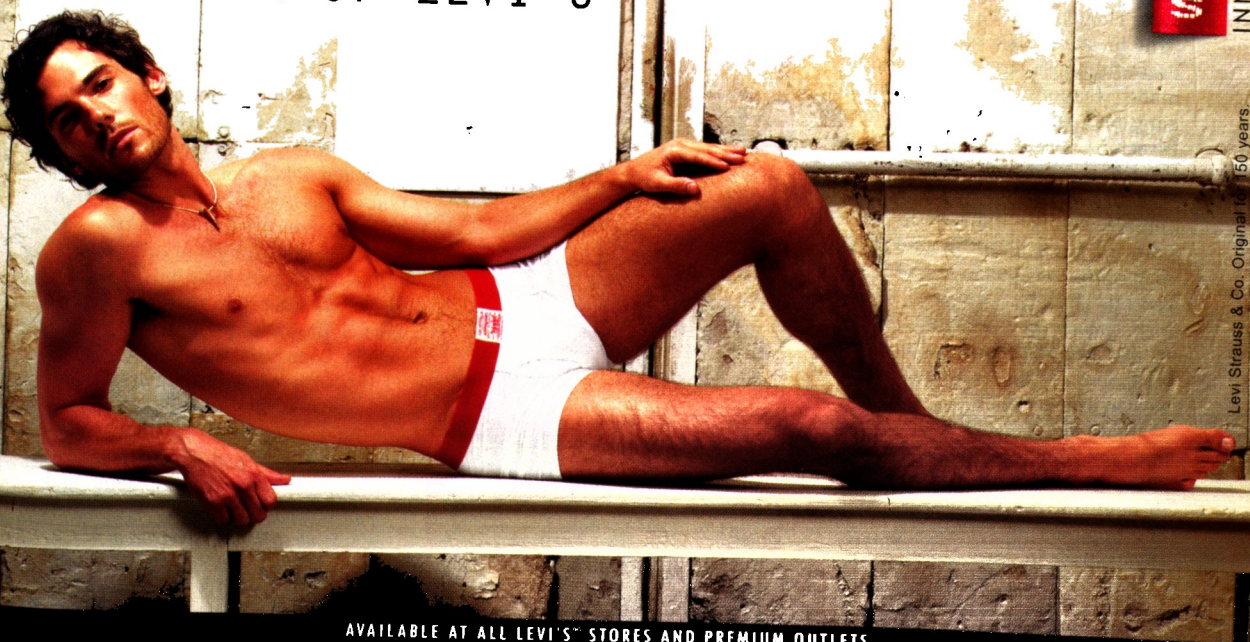
sensitisation to violence."

The image of the gun-toting criminal has changed as professionals, businessmen, students, even housewives, are increasingly gaining access to guns. So, are lax licencing laws to be blamed for this untoward trend? Delhi alone has 40,000 licenced weapons. According to reports, 8,801 cases relating to the Arms Act were registered in Delhi in last two years. Little wonder then that in 2007 alone, 35 people were

shot dead by firearms in the Capital. Says a senior Delhi police officer, "In Delhi, the number of licenced weapons is 40,000 but the number of illegal firearms is double. Licenced weapons are mostly used in cases of suicide or domestic violence." The situation in Mumbai is no different. While records show that only 71 licences were issued in 2006 and only 90 have been handed out till now this year, the ground reality is quite different. Deven Bharti, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Detection, Crime Branch, CID, Mumbai, confirms that the number of applications for gun licences in Mumbai has indeed gone up. "Since we issue licences based on merit and reject most applications, the guns are procured illegally. It cannot be denied that people have easy access to country-made revolvers that enter the state from Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and other northern states," he says.

But still India's gun culture is not comparable to a place like America where, in most states, you can simply walk into a gun shop and purchase a weapon just by showing proof of age. Here it is more difficult for civilians to

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